

Talking to Yourself Kindly ★ ELEVATED

DURATION	40 min · Week 4
OBJECTIVE	Students write a self-compassion letter to themselves and articulate what makes self-compassion different from self-pity or excusing mistakes.
CASEL FOCUS	Self-Management: self-compassion practice · Self-Awareness: honest and kind self-talk
VOCABULARY	self-compassion, kindness, honest, letter, friend voice
MATERIALS	Journals · WS5 Letter From Your Best Friend · Teacher model letter (prepared in advance)

SAFETY CHECK — COMPLETE BEFORE DELIVERING

Counselor notified — minimum 1 week in advance. · Counselor reachable on the day. · Lesson NOT scheduled before a school break. · Reflection Pass pre-positioned at every student seat. · AFSP Safe Messaging applies. If student language shifts from feeling to self ("I want to get rid of myself"), STOP immediately and activate the Disclosure Protocol.

OPENING REVIEW

2 Minutes

"Once you have owned a mistake and started repair — then comes the part we skip most often: being kind to yourself about it."

I

The Friend Test — Opening Hook

2–8 MIN

"If your best friend came to you after making a mistake — what would you say?" Students write for 90 seconds. Then: "Do you ever say that to YOURSELF?" Very few hands. "Why not?" This gap is Dr. Neff's foundational research finding.

2

Direct Instruction

8–16 MIN

SELF-COMPASSION IS: (1) Self-kindness: speak with care, not contempt. (2) Common humanity: everyone struggles — you are not uniquely broken. (3) Mindfulness: notice what happened without dramatizing or suppressing. SELF-COMPASSION IS NOT: a free pass or pretending it was fine.

ANCHOR CHART · DR. NEFF'S THREE COMPONENTS OF SELF-COMPASSION

Post BEFORE students begin writing. They use it as a checklist: Does my letter include self-kindness? Common humanity? Mindfulness?